

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENTS AND DECISION-MAKING SHORTCUTS IN THE 2000 ELECTION

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Studies of political campaigns often focus on the manner in which candidates communicate messages, and the content of those messages, with the assumption that candidate rhetoric and issue platforms mean something to the voter. People who have a good understanding of politics and exhibit high levels of political interest are expected to be particularly attentive to candidate messages. Political psychologists believe that, in fact, the opposite is true. They suggest that well-informed and interested citizens make political judgments early and on the basis of little information, relying instead on a few simple cues to form opinions about candidates and issues. Students of rhetoric may be dissecting the meanings of candidates' speeches and their debate styles, but voters are not. The key to understanding how citizens evaluate politics is the schema.

What is a Political Schema?

Strictly speaking, political psychologists define a schema as a structuring element of a political belief system that determines relationships among various political opinions and attitudes. As a source of structure, a schema acts as a decision making shortcut that citizens can use to process political (or any other type) of information. The assumption underlying many theories about political information processing is that citizens are cognitive misers whenever possible. That is, they would prefer to evaluate political issues in an uncomplicated manner that is not cognitively demanding. Instead, they seek out simple associations between the object being evaluated, be it a candidate, a party, or a political issue, and some pre-existing set of beliefs or values.

Political scientists and psychologists have identified a wide variety of schemata commonly used by citizens in making political judgments, including partisanship (Hamill,

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Lodge, & Blake, 1985; Lodge & Hamill, 1986; Jacoby, 1988), social class (Hamill, Lodge, & Blake, 1985), and political ideology (Conover & Feldman, 1980; Pierce & Hagner, 1980; Knight, 1985; Hamill, Lodge, & Blake, 1985; see also Converse, 1964). Citizens may also use group identifications such as race or gender, or group affect, as shortcuts in forming candidate evaluations (Allen, Dawson, & Brown, 1989; Conover & Feldman, 1984; Sniderman, Brody, & Tetlock, 1991).

Erber and Lau (1990) find that some individuals are predisposed to evaluate political events on the basis of issues/policy alternatives, while others may focus on the persons involved in the policy debate. Wattenberg (1990, 1991) has suggested that the decline of strong partisans in the electorate and the increasing autonomy of political campaigns on the national level has led to a more candidate-centered (or person-centered) political environment. He believes that personal qualities such as honesty, empathy, and intelligence, in addition to leadership skills and political experience, are becoming more central to voters' decision-making processes (see also Miller, Wattenberg, & Malanchuk, 1986). Thus, many voters may be amenable to candidate appeals that focus on personality rather than political issues.

Whether a citizen will utilize a particular schema depends upon the availability of that schema in the individual's mental repertoire, the presence of cues in the political environment, and chronic accessibility (Lau, 1989). Chronic accessibility is somewhat like media priming. According to Lau, a schema that has been activated recently is more likely to be utilized because it will be more salient for the citizen. Thus, cues such as partisanship, which tend to be frequent themes in elite discourse and media coverage of political events, should be readily available to most potential voters.

A common misperception of decision-making shortcuts is that they are relied upon primarily by those who are less politically engaged, and thus less equipped to make decisions about complex issues. Studies in information processing, however, suggest that this is not the case. Rather, it is individuals with greater levels of interest in politics that tend to have the most well-developed, broad ranging, and complex political belief systems. Thus, those with more interest and political experience should rely on a small number of schemata to formulate judgments on a wide range of political candidates and issues (Converse, 1964; see also Lodge, McGraw, Conover, Feldman, & Miller, 1991). Such decision making shortcuts can also be used to assist voters in making rational inferences about candidates when limited information is available (Fiske & Taylor, 1984).

How Candidates Manipulate Voter Schemata in a Political Campaign

A political candidate should be able to manipulate the use of political schemata in much the same way as groups or individuals (the media, political parties, or political candidates) frame political issues or set the political agenda. Through their word choice, or through their choice of imagery, they can evoke associations with political party leaders, labor unions, civil rights leaders, middle class families, big business, or the wealthy (Miller & Levitan, 1976).

This is somewhat more simplistic than framing an argument to appeal to a potential voter, although candidates obviously do this as well. A schema is, in a broad sense, a shortcut for a series of arguments that candidates could make, but do not have to if they are able to evoke a schema already possessed by the voter. For example, a voter with a well-developed ideological schema generally already has a set of beliefs about what liberals and conservatives stand for (in terms of both their basic orientations toward the role of government as well as their positions on specific policy issues), and he should also be fairly certain of his own personal ideological orientation. Thus, when a candidate is presented as a conservative (as a result of self-labeling or labeling by an opponent), the voter can make a variety of inferences about that candidate's position on government spending on social programs, abortion, gun control, prayer in schools, the power of federal versus local governments, and so on. If a candidate expects a large percentage of their target audience to have a well-developed ideological schema, it is in the candidate's interest to evoke that schema. By claiming to be a "traditional conservative," the candidate need not make arguments to voters about the size of government, gun control, or abortion. Rather, the *voter* makes the argument. The conservative voter who wishes to vote for the conservative candidate already knows the issues that she considers important, and she is free to decide which ones she will use to justify her vote choice.

Themes and Associations in the Bush-Cheney and Gore-Lieberman Campaign Ads

Political campaign ads provide a setting in which voters should be expected to use schemata, when available, to aid them in determining how they feel about the candidates and for whom they should cast a ballot. Research on political information processing suggests that organizing information around a candidate theme (i.e., as occurs in a campaign

advertisement) tends to be more amenable to schematic processing. Information organized by “item” (policy position, party, or some other comparative theme) is more difficult to process and may compel voters to abandon decision-making shortcuts (i.e., schemata) for more complicated, time-consuming processing routines often referred to as “piecemeal processing” (see Fiske, 1986; Herstein, 1981).

This analysis will focus on a collection of ads run by the major party candidates during the post-nomination phase of the recent presidential campaign. The audience in the primary season is generally composed of political partisans and occasional independents, whereas the post-nomination phase of the campaign has a more universal audience, and should entail more diverse candidate appeals. The ads examined were selected on the basis of their typicality (in terms of the types of themes used by the candidates) and the extent to which they attempted to appeal to decision-making shortcuts. Due to space limitations, not all types of candidate appeals could be examined.

Leadership Appeals. Often, the theme of the campaign ad is not the issue that it purports to discuss. This is generally the case with leadership appeals in campaign ads. Few ads focus strictly on a candidate’s leadership qualities. Rather, leadership appeals are cloaked in the context of some other political issue. A closer inspection, however, should reveal that such ads are not really about the issue being portrayed. For example, in an advertisement by the Bush-Cheney campaign entitled “Phyllis Hunter,” Ms. Hunter, an African American educator, tells how education in Texas has improved since Bush became governor. Ms. Hunter explicitly claims that she supports Bush because he is a leader. The commercial concludes with footage of Bush claiming that “reading is a new civil right.” There is little offered in the way of specific policy accomplishments of the Bush administration in reading, nor are any policy proposals enumerated. Rather, the theme of this commercial is that Bush is a “leader” and that he has been inspiring to educators. The viewer is being asked to evaluate the candidate on the basis of personal qualities, rather than on his education policy.

Gore’s promotion of his own leadership skills is more subtle. Often, this takes the form of detailed issue ads where citizens are given the impression that Gore has thought carefully about a policy problem and has formulated specific solutions, or ads where Gore portrays himself as battling some opponent (such as health insurance companies). In “Veteran,” for example, the Gore campaign claims: “Al Gore will fight for families. Tax cuts for middle class families including a \$10,000 a year tax deduction for college tuition. Continue welfare

reform with time limits, work requirements.” In addition to the other specific policies enumerated in the ad, “Veteran” concludes on this note: “Al Gore. He’ll put his values to work for us.”

Gore also makes a series of appeals to the leadership theme in his ads that criticize George Bush. For example, in “Judge,” Gore attacks Bush’s health care policy in Texas. The ad notes: “Texas ranks 49th out of 50 in providing health coverage to kids. It’s so bad a federal judge just ruled Texas must take immediate corrective action.” After discussing Bush’s broken promises on health care, the ad concludes with the following: “The Bush record--it’s becoming an issue.”

A similar attack on Bush’s leadership abilities appears in the Gore-Lieberman ad aptly entitled “Lead.” In addition to accusations of poor health care, pollution, and the low minimum wage in Texas, the Gore campaign suggests: “Now Bush promises the same one trillion dollars from Social Security to two different groups. He squanders the surplus on a tax cut for those making over \$300,000 dollars. Is he ready to lead America?” Over the course of the campaign, Gore used these ads and others, such as “Oil and Water,” to draw attention to Bush’s record in Texas in an attempt to show that Bush has not been a successful political leader.

Personal Qualities/ Candidate Character. An important theme in most contemporary presidential campaigns is the candidate’s personal integrity and trustworthiness. Gore’s strategy is to question Bush’s honesty in the context of Bush’s policy proposals. In the Gore-Lieberman ad entitled “Penny,” Gore suggests that Bush used distorted figures in support of his social security plan. The ad begins with a head and shoulders shot of Bush speaking, with the following phrase displayed in white: “Will he come clean on social security?” The ad goes on to claim that Bush’s numbers don’t add up. A narrator claims: “Now George Bush is promising young workers one trillion dollars in social security for them to invest. But, the same money is needed to pay current benefits. If Bush gives it away, it could cut benefits for seniors.”

The ad also utilizes Bush’s primary opponent, John McCain, who nicknamed his campaign the “straight talk express.” The ad shows footage of McCain speaking, while a narrator notes that: “In this year’s election, John McCain said Bush’s plan has not one penny for social security.” The conclusion of the ad makes an additional, more veiled reference to McCain: “Think about it. George Bush is promising young workers and seniors the same money. That’s anything but straight talk.” The implication is clear:

George Bush is attempting to mislead voters about the feasibility of his social security plan. Gore uses a member of Bush's own political party against him in an attempt to discredit Bush. The fact that the ad contains no footage of Gore nor any information about Gore's social security plan suggests that this is not, in fact, an ad about social security per se. Rather, the voter is being asked to evaluate Bush's political expertise and his honesty.

The Republican strategy for character appeals is less issue-based and more personal in nature. The RNC ran an ad that was much more direct in its questioning of Gore's honesty. In "Really," sponsored by the RNC, listeners hear a woman's voice, somewhat sarcastically, proclaiming: "Oh, there's Al Gore, reinventing himself on television again... like I'm not gonna notice! Who's he gonna be today? The Al Gore who raises campaign money at a Buddhist temple? Or the one who now promises campaign finance reform? Really! Al Gore--claiming credit for things he didn't even do." The ad then uses audio of Al Gore claiming: "I took the initiative in creating the internet." Gore's claim about the Internet was a well-known falsehood at this point in the campaign and served to remind voters of a tangible instance in which the candidate was not truthful.

Around the same time, The RNC ran an ad entitled "Let's See," which suggested that Al Gore's promises of campaign finance reform were disingenuous. According to the ad: "Because of Gore's last fundraising campaign 22 people have been indicted, 12 convicted, 70 took the fifth amendment and 18 witnesses have fled the country." The ad goes on to question his commitment to school accountability, flatly implying that the candidate has been involved in illegal activities and thus cannot be trusted. The RNC ads made much more explicit claims of dishonesty than ads run by Gore-Lieberman and the DNC; clearly, Republican leaders hoped to cue voters to consider personal qualities and character when evaluating both candidates and political issues in general.

Partisan and Ideological Appeals. Given the relative accessibility of a partisan schema for most voters, candidates attempt to evoke partisan loyalty through the use of symbols such as well-known party figures and traditional party campaign themes. For example, the Bush-Cheney campaign ran an ad that asked: "Whose economic plan is best for you?" According to the ad: "Under George Bush's plan, a family earning under \$35,000 a year pays no federal income taxes. A 100% tax cut. Earn \$35-\$50,000 -- a 55% tax cut." The ad then proclaims: "Tax relief for everyone." There is virtually no indication of how such a tax plan would be funded, nor is there any attempt to compare Bush's tax plan to alternatives proposed by Gore. Rather, the ad concludes: "And Al Gore's plan--three times

the new spending President Clinton proposed. So much it wipes out the entire surplus and creates a deficit again. Al Gore's deficit spending plan threatens Americans' prosperity."

Bush's *tax* plan is compared to Gore's *spending* plan, not Gore's tax plan. Bush's own spending plan (i.e., his large proposed increases in defense spending) is not addressed. Rather, the ad focuses on Clinton and addresses Republican tax cuts and the Democrats' spending agenda. Given the lack of statistics, comparisons, or expert testimony, the purpose of the ad does not appear to be to persuade viewers of the merits of Bush's tax plan. Rather, it seeks to establish connections between Gore and other Democratic leaders (in this case, Clinton) and to evoke a stereotype of Gore as a "tax-and-spend Democrat." Thus, the appeal of the ad is rooted in partisanship, rather than the tax issue itself.

We see a similar approach in an October 10th Bush-Cheney/RNC ad on education reform entitled "Education Recession." In this ad, Bush's campaign claims that there is an education recession in America. Specifically, they claim: "Our students are last in the world in math and physics and most 4th graders in our cities can't read." And, there is a clear assignment of blame: "The Clinton-Gore education recession. It's failing our kids." The term "recession" is a loaded one and is potentially more powerful than merely claiming that an education "crisis" exists. In a crisis, the consequences are imminent, whereas in a recession they have already arrived.

The conclusion of the ad offers little in the way of a specific policy vision. Rather, potential voters are told that "in Texas, George Bush raised standards and test scores soared. Now Texas leads the nation in academic improvement. Learn more about the Bush blueprint for accountability, high standards, and local control." The ad asks citizens to put their faith in Bush's leadership skills, rather than listing any elements of a policy agenda. In this sense, it is not an issue ad, but a partisan-oriented appeal with a secondary appeal on the basis of leadership skills.

Social Class Appeals. In the 2000 election, the Bush-Cheney campaign did not prompt voters to consider their social class. Bush ads tend to focus on appeals designed to be more universal, such as the claim of "tax relief for everyone" seen in the Bush ad on taxes discussed above. In "Trust," Bush criticizes Gore for a fiscal policy that does not offer across-the-board tax relief: "My opponent proposes targeted tax cuts only for those he calls the right people. And that means half of all income taxpayers get nothing at all."

Gore's approach to the tax issue is very different from Bush's. Rather than making promises to all potential voters ("tax relief for everyone"), he makes an explicitly class-based appeal. In an ad on fiscal discipline and tax cuts entitled "Trickle," the Gore-Lieberman campaign offers viewers "the facts on George Bush's 1.6 trillion dollar tax cut promise." They claim: "Almost half goes to the richest 1 percent. What trickles down--an average of 62 cents a pay for most taxpayers. Bush gives almost half to the richest 1%, leaving 62 cents to trickle down to us."

In addition to making clear distinctions between "us" and the "richest 1 percent of Americans," Gore evokes images of Reagan's economic policies with the repetition of the phrase "trickle down" (the phrase is used three times). Thus, he is making both a class-based and a partisan appeal to voters.

Gore makes a similar appeal in "Training," where he suggests that current education funding helps wealthy business executives more than it does the average American. "Training" claims: "Big corporations get a tax write off for education or training for their high-paid executives. But for hard-working, middle-class families, you don't get enough help to afford your kids' college tuition." The ad suggests economic redistribution in education assistance and, therefore, attempts to activate social class concerns among potential voters.

Two "Bigs": Government and Business. In many cases, the two campaigns opted to make more veiled partisan and ideological appeals by manipulating images of business and government. For the Gore campaign, the focus was almost never on the Republicans as a party or past Republican political leaders. Rather, partisan appeals were indirect, focusing on class-based appeals and attacks on big business. While the Bush campaign did make a variety of explicit and negative references to the Clinton administration, they also opted for a variety of attacks on the federal government.

The Bush-Cheney campaign ran several ads that attempted to paint the Democrats as the party of "big government." Several of these were of the more subtle type, as represented by "Trust," run by Bush-Cheney 2000 and the RNC. In "Trust," Bush outlines his basic philosophy on government: "I believe we need to encourage personal responsibility so people are accountable for their actions. And I believe in government that is responsible to the people. That's the difference in philosophy between my opponent and me."

What "personal responsibility" and "accountability" mean is not initially clear. Both are valence issues—responsibility and accountability are generally considered desirable things,

and few people are opposed to them. Thus, they are not “issues” in the true sense of the word until some form of implementation is identified, allowing citizens to consider the pros and cons of an action being proposed.

As the ad progresses, the meaning of these terms becomes clear. Bush states: “He [Gore] trusts government. I trust you.” Government is identified as a problem, or an institution not deserving of trust. This theme is present throughout the ad. Bush trusts voters to “invest some of your own social security money for higher returns,” with the implication being that the federal government is inefficient in handling social security revenue. Bush also trusts “local people to run their own schools,” although he suggests that if they do not perform, “we will give parents different options.” Bush trusts citizens “with some of the budget surplus.” The role of the federal government should be small. According to Bush: “We should help people live their lives, but not run them.” While Bush does not use the phrase “big government” in this ad, he overtly suggests that the federal government is ineffective in managing federally funded programs.

The RNC is more explicit in an ad on prescription drugs entitled “Notebook.” In “Notebook,” Bush and Gore’s prescription drug plans are compared in two adjacent columns. According to the ad: “Al Gore will charge seniors a new \$600 a year government access fee. George Bush opposes Gore’s \$600 fee. Gore’s plan--when seniors turn 64 they must join a drug HMO selected by Washington or they’re on their own.” Gore is identified with the federal government both in terms of fees and HMO management. The on-screen association is more explicit than the verbal commentary. When the narrator is discussing the negative aspects of Gore’s proposal, the phrase “Charge seniors \$600 big government access fee annually” appears on the screen in the column representing Gore’s plan.

The ad makes several references, both verbal and visual, to Gore’s “government HMO” that seniors will be “forced to join.” Thus, the ad attempts to create negative associations between Gore and HMOs and Gore and an intrusive federal government. Again, the specifics of Bush’s plan are not enumerated and constitute a small part of the ad. It is sufficient for the potential voter to know that Gore is in favor of big government involvement and Bush is opposed to it. A similar, although toned-down connection between Gore and government HMOs is made in the RNC ad entitled “Federal,” and the RNC/Bush-Cheney ad entitled “Compare.” Negative associations with the federal government are the cornerstone of the Republican response to Gore’s prescription drug plan.

Gore makes similar negative connections between Bush and the private sector. In an ad entitled "Oil and Water," Gore attacks Bush's record on the environment in Texas. According to the Gore campaign: "After 17 years in the oil business, George W. Bush ran for governor and then passed laws to let big polluters regulate themselves. Today Texas is #3 in water pollution and #1 in air pollution." Bush is explicitly connected to the oil industry, and environmental problems in Texas are attributed to this business affiliation.

The Gore campaign also attempts to connect Bush with big business in numerous ads on health care. In an ad run by the DNC entitled "Siding," for example, Bush is accused of leaving many seniors out of his prescription drug plan. According to the ad: "Bush forces seniors he does include to go to HMOs and insurance companies for coverage. The National Council of Senior Citizens says the Bush approach is favored by big drug companies and leaves millions with no help." The use of the phrase "big drug companies" is clearly designed to evoke negative feelings about the pharmaceutical industry. As Schuman and Presser (1981) note, citizens tend to respond more negatively when asked about "big government" and "big business" than they do when asked simply about "government" and "business." The phrase "big drug companies" appears three times in the audio portion of the commercial, and twice in writing on screen. In each instance, Gore is portrayed as "taking on big drug companies" and Bush is referred to as "siding with big drug companies." Gore makes similar arguments about fighting against drug companies and insurance companies in several ads, including "Bean Counter," "Cover," and "Book."

Are Themes from Campaign Ads Present in Citizens' Candidate Evaluations?

Knowing the type of schema a candidate is attempting to activate is only part of the story of a political campaign. To find out how the story ends, we need to know if the candidate was successful in getting potential voters to use the preferred schema in formulating political judgments. In the case of campaign ads, this is a particularly difficult task in the 2000 election because ads in the general election were aired primarily in the 17 battleground states. Given that the campaign ads examined here reflect the same themes that the candidates attempted to convey (although less expertly) in political debates and televised appearances, it is likely that potential voters were somewhat familiar with the messages whether they had directly viewed a particular ad or not. In the case of certain ads such as the "Rats" ad, media coverage of the ad itself served to disseminate the theme of the Bush-Cheney campaign to media markets not initially targeted.

The most reliable and comprehensive source of data on citizen attitudes about the 2000 election is the American National Election Studies series, conducted by the Center for Political Studies at the University of Michigan. It is the only national academic survey on American electoral behavior. The National Election Study provides citizens with a variety of opportunities to express their views on political candidates. One of the most valuable means, for the purposes of this essay, is the series of open-ended questions on what the survey respondents liked and disliked about each candidate. The reason the open-ended questions are so valuable is that they are one of the few glimpses we have into what was on the minds of potential voters. Most commercial and academic surveys on election-related themes involve close-ended nominal or ordinal questions about candidate and issue preferences. The problem with such questions is that the survey researcher mediates the types of responses individuals can make through the selection of possible response categories, and the types of questions asked reflect the needs of the researchers, and not necessarily the themes most salient to the respondent (although the two need not be mutually exclusive). Open-ended questions in survey research are rare because they are difficult to administer; however, they are desirable because they permit respondents to decide if they have an opinion to express (absent cueing about specific issues or traits) and which perceptions are important to them.

The 2000 National Election Study asked respondents to list things they liked and disliked about each candidate in the pre-election portion of the study. Interviews began at the end of August and continued through the end of October. This is desirable because this is the time period when most ads were run. Only the first stated “like” and “dislike” for each candidate will be analyzed. This is because only half of all survey respondents were able to provide a single reason for liking and disliking a candidate; the number dwindles substantially after the first response. Additionally, a first response can be helpful in determining which elements of the campaign were most salient for the potential voter as it taps what is at “the top of the head.”

Table 1 summarizes the types of remarks respondents made about each candidate when we combine the favorable comments about Gore with the unfavorable remarks about Bush, and the favorable Bush remarks with the unfavorable Gore comments. This enables us to assess what kinds of cues are being utilized by potential voters and whether the net pro-Gore feelings differed from the net pro-Bush feelings. As Table 1 demonstrates, political issues were salient to voters, but they matter somewhat more for potential voters who preferred

Gore. This is consistent with Gore's emphasis on the advantages and disadvantages of proposed policies during the campaign. Personal/character cues were also important to respondents, but more so for those who preferred Bush. Indeed, a full quarter of the total reasons potential voters gave for preferring Bush involved his personal qualities. Given the prominence of personal characteristics in the Bush ad campaign, the campaign seems to have been successful in getting citizens to focus on the candidate as a person. The Bush campaign was substantially less successful in triggering evaluations based on the candidate's leadership qualities. Fewer than 10 % mention leadership as a reason for liking Bush or disliking Gore.

Table 1.
Images of Gore and Bush: Likes and Dislikes Sorted by Direction

	pro-Gore	pro-Bush
Issue (foreign or domestic)	37.9%	31.0%
Personal	18.5%	25.3%
Party	14.0%	18.2%
Political experience	10.1%	3.7%
Governing philosophy	4.2%	8.0%
Group reference	8.0%	2.6%
Government management	1.5%	2.1%
Leadership	3.0%	6.5%
Other	2.7%	2.6%

Source: 2000 American National Election Study

Note: Cell entries are the percentage of respondents who responded to the like and/or the dislike question about the candidate. The implied denominator in this case is the total number of individuals who expressed a like about the candidate and/or a dislike about their opponent.

N = 1041 for Bush; N = 1107 for Gore

The partisan schema appeared to be fairly accessible to many potential voters, although slightly more Bush supporters mentioned a partisan reason in evaluating their candidate. Governing philosophy was a less accessible cue, although more accessible to Bush supporters than Gore supporters. Combined, partisan and ideological cues were more likely to be used in ways that favored Bush than in ways that favored Gore. Given that Gore ran very few partisan-oriented ads relative to Bush, perhaps this should not be surprising.

A closer examination of the content of the issue-related remarks made in response to the like-dislike questions will reveal that the use of party-based information shortcuts also lurks beneath issue evaluations. A partial breakdown of the themes present in issue-oriented

responses is shown in Table 2. Of particular interest here are the items on abortion, gun control, and law and order (including comments about drugs). These themes were generally not addressed by candidates in their political advertisements, and they played only a minor role, if that, in the televised debates and nightly soundbites of the campaign. However, they have been perennial themes in most presidential campaigns, and the parties have staked out well-known and differing positions on these issues. Thus, citizens with chronically accessible party schemata should be equipped to make inferences about the candidates on these issues absent any explicit appeal during the campaign.

Table 2.
Breakdown of Issue Comments by Area

	Pro-Gore	pro-Bush
Education	15.8%	15.3%
Taxes	5.3%	10.7%
Social security	11.4%	5.3%
Abortion	15.6%	22.0%
Health care/prescription drugs	20.1%	10.1%
Environment	18.0%	8.7%
Gun control	4.4%	15.3%
Law and order/drugs	0.0%	4.0%
Family values	1.9%	3.0%
Economy	6.8%	1.7%

Source: 2000 American National Election Study

Note: Cell entries are the percentage of respondents who responded to the like and/or the dislike question about the candidate. The implied denominator in this case is the total number of individuals who expressed a like about the candidate and/or a dislike about their opponent with respect to a domestic policy issue.

N = 300 for Bush; N = 411 for Gore

As Table 2 illustrates, many citizens were able to make such inferences. Over 15% of the positive issue-based assessments of Al Gore mentioned abortion, and a full 22% of the issue-based comments in Bush's favor were abortion-related. While gun control was not given by most citizens as a reason for favoring Gore (such responses are present in only 4.4% of his issue-based remarks), over 15% of positive Bush assessments mention his stance on guns. None of the issue-based reasons potential voters gave for favoring Gore mentioned law and order or drugs, but 4% of the positive Bush assessments did. Thus, just under 19% of the positive issue-oriented assessments of Gore and just over 40% of the positive issue-oriented assessments of Bush were based on partisan inferences, rather than

actual arguments made by the candidates during the campaign. For citizens with chronically accessible partisan schemata, the candidates did not need to make these arguments; they were simply assumed.¹

While Gore made a variety of class-based and partisan-based appeals to voters during the campaign, it is not clear from the data shown in Table 2 that citizens evaluated them using a class-based schema. Few pro-Gore assessments (5.3%), and substantially more pro-Bush comments (10.7%), centered on the tax issue. That such a major redistributive issue was not more prevalent in the minds of survey respondents sheds doubt on the power of class as a decision-making cue. Moreover, only 6.8% of the issue-based remarks favorable to Gore mentioned some element of the economy (and only 1.7% of issue based remarks favorable to Bush did so, which is not surprising given that Gore was a member of an incumbent administration that was associated with the most sustained period of economic growth in the post-war era).² However, the full effects of a class-based appeal cannot be assessed here because of their strong connection with a citizen's political party identification (see Stonecash, 2000). The persistent correlation between a citizen's social class and their

¹ As the Vanishing Voter Project (2000a) notes, inferences made by voters are often incorrect, particularly in cases where the candidate takes a non-traditional issue stance. In a November 5 poll, they find that 18 percent of citizens incorrectly assumed that Al Gore favored placing substantial restrictions on trade with China due to human rights issues; a mere 14 percent of respondents correctly gauged Gore's position. 68 percent did not know Gore's position. The lack of clear-cut partisan positions also poses problems for voters. Only 19 percent of respondents correctly identified Bush as being opposed to a ban on very large contributions to political candidates. 22 percent of respondents mistakenly thought Bush favored such a ban, while a full 59 percent did not know. Voters were much more likely to gauge a candidate's position correctly, and much less likely to answer "don't know," when candidates took predictable partisan positions on traditional issues.

² The item on the economy includes remarks about the degree of government control over the economy, monetary policy, whether economic times generally (and inflation, wages, employment, producer prices) are associated with the candidate in a positive or negative way, and whether the candidate is perceived as able to halt or diminish a perceived gap between rich and poor Americans. It does not include items on welfare policy, or employment and labor policy.

political party identification throughout the post-war era makes it difficult to disentangle the effects of each from the other without more complex multivariate modeling techniques.

The problem with the candidate likes and dislikes is that they reveal very little in the way of class-oriented evaluations or ideological evaluations, even though political psychologists have found that such cues are useful to many voters (the percentage of respondents making group references and governing philosophy comments were very small in all cases). This is because partisanship is strongly related to both political ideology and socio-economic status, and may mask the use of class-based and ideological schemata by voters. A simple test for the relationship between group identity and candidate affect is shown in Table 3. Candidate affect is measured by 100-point feeling thermometer ratings, where respondents are asked to place each candidate on a scale where 1 indicates extremely cool feelings and 100 indicates extremely warm feelings. Respondents were also asked to rate a variety of social groups on this scale. The items are taken from the post-election portion of the National Election Study. The cell entries in Table 3 are bivariate product-moment correlations between group affect and candidate affect. Positive correlations indicate that as affect for the group goes up, so does affect for the candidate (and, conversely, as affect for the group goes down, so does affect for the candidate). Negative correlations mean that as people tend to like the group, they tend to dislike the candidate (and vice versa). Correlations that are not statistically significant indicate that there is no meaningful relationship between feelings about the group and feelings about the candidate.

As Table 3 shows, feelings about the federal government in Washington are positively related to *both* candidates, although more weakly to Bush than to Gore. Given Bush's anti-federal government campaign, this is somewhat surprising at first glance. However, what the data suggest is that people who have strong negative feelings about the federal government tend to dislike all political candidates (indeed, research on political efficacy suggests that such individuals are also unlikely to vote). Bush did not succeed in activating anti-government schemata among voters, or persuading individuals with strong anti-government sentiment to support his candidacy.

Predictably, liberals favored Gore and disliked Bush. And, conservatives favored Bush and disliked Gore (to about the same degree). Thus, despite the lack of open-ended likes and dislikes that dealt with ideology, citizens were very polarized in their ideological evaluations of Gore and Bush, suggesting that ideological schemata were a factor in how voters viewed the candidates.

Table 3.
Group Affect and Candidate Affect (Feeling Thermometer Ratings)

	Feelings about Gore	Feelings about Bush
Federal Government in Washington	.33* (1487)	.06* (1486)
Liberals	.50* (1427)	-.30* (1426)
Conservatives	-.27* (1430)	.47* (1430)
Labor Unions	.40* (1455)	-.19* (1459)
Big Business	-.01 (1482)	.28* (1483)
Poor People	.14* (1434)	.01 (1434)
People on Welfare	.25* (1433)	-.06* (1433)

Source: 2000 National Election Study

* $p \leq .05$, two-tailed test

Note: Cell entries are bivariate product-moment correlations. Figures in parentheses are sample sizes

There are several somewhat imperfect measures that also may be used to test for the presence of class-based schemata. Given the pervasive class theme in Gore's campaign, both in terms of his ads about Bush benefiting the rich and his anti-big business themes, it makes sense to examine feelings about the candidates in the context of feelings about labor and big business. As Table 3 shows, there is a noticeable rift among the candidates in terms of how they are viewed by pro-labor respondents. People with positive feelings about labor unions tended to like Gore, and they also tended to dislike Bush. Interestingly, people who felt warmly about big business liked Bush, and people who felt cool about big business disliked Bush. However, there was no significant relationship between how people felt about big business and how people felt about Gore. This suggests that despite his efforts,

Gore was not viewed as the anti-big business candidate, although Gore was successful in helping to portray Bush as the pro-big business candidate.

Unfortunately, this time around the National Election Study did not include ratings of rich people, working people, or the middle class. There are, however, ratings of poor people and people on welfare. Predictably, people with warm feelings about the poor and people on welfare also felt warmly about Gore, and people with cool feelings about this group had cool feelings about Gore. How respondents felt about poor people had no effect on how they felt about Bush. But, respondents who disliked people on welfare tended to feel warmly about Bush. Gore is clearly understood by voters to be the candidate of the less advantaged. There is some evidence that Bush is perceived as more hostile to the interests of the lower classes.

Overall, the survey data on voter attitudes in the 2000 election suggest that there is some covariation between themes emphasized by candidates in political advertisements and voter images of candidates. There is also evidence that voters are making inferences on the basis of political schemata such as partisanship. This still leaves us with a nagging chicken-and-egg question: Is there covariance because candidates are able to successfully manipulate voter schemata, or is there covariance because candidates are adept at ascertaining the schemata voters are predisposed to utilize? Political scholars continue to grapple with this question.

From the perspective of democratic politics, however, the mere presence of covariation is somewhat heartening because it suggests that despite the very low levels of political information possessed by citizens during presidential elections, many are still capable of responding to themes that are simple and making use of basic decision-making shortcuts. Most Americans simply don't care about politics at all, even when the time to make an important political decision is at hand. Presidential elections are generally the most salient and garner the highest levels of political participation. Yet, according to the Vanishing Voter Index of Political Involvement, a scant 50% of American citizens registered some form of interest in the presidential election in the week that the election took place (Vanishing Voter, 2000b). (That number rose to 73% the week following the election as a result of the contested outcome in Florida.³) In the weeks preceding the election, interest

³ The Involvement Index is compiled on the basis of survey questions regarding citizens' attention to the campaign, exposure to news, participation in political discussions, and time spent thinking about the election (Vanishing Voter, 2000b).

levels were substantially lower, suggesting that Americans were not actively seeking out information about the candidates. Political schemata provide a meaningful way for many citizens to make coherent political decisions whether they have the resources to gather large amounts of political information or not. Given simple decision-making shortcuts, potential voters need only locate a few cues about candidates or issues to make a vote choice that corresponds to their underlying political interests. In short, while voters might operate with far less information than many scholars would wish for, their decisions are still rational rather than arbitrary. With so many voters likely to operate on the basis of minimal information, their ability to make internally consistent decisions that they believe to be in their own interests should give those of us who study voting behavior and public argument some comfort.

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